

HOW TO CHOOSE BASIC CONSUMER ELECTRONICS

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What drives your decision to buy an appliance for your house?

Are you mesmerised by the fascinating ads or do you know your needs? Are you clear with the criteria you need to check before going for a particular model? This article will try to help you decide how to buy a few basic appliances that most people need. It will help you list the deciding factors for a new appliance before buying online or offline. Let us explore four appliances: washing machines, refrigerators, food processors and water purifiers.

Washing machines

Let us start with washing machines. Factors to consider are as follows: fully-automatic or semi-automatic; top load or front load; wash types; price; family size (wash capacity in kgs) and warranty period.

There are a few standard washes that a fully-automatic washing machine must include: daily wear (normal), woolens, heavy clothes (jeans or bed-sheets), wash, rinse, spin, soak and soft wash (light or gentle wash). There are other wash options in high-end models, such as sarees, whites, synthetics, hard water wash and so on.

A semi-automatic machine has two separate tubs for washing and drying. Once the wash-



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Top-load washing machine versus front-load washing machine (Credit: www.bestforyourhome.co.in)

ing is complete, it needs human intervention to drop clothes in the drying tub. This feature makes the process time-consuming, and you are not free to do other jobs. Although it is cheaper than a fully-automatic machine, the latter has a big advantage. You only need to start the machine, and the rest it does on its own and indicates by alarm once washing is done.

Top load is a good option for those who suffer from frequent power cuts. It is easier to use, washes quicker and requires less maintenance. Whereas, front load is gentler on the clothes, can take larger loads, cleans better, is more energy- and water-efficient. However, front-load washers are more expensive than top-load ones (there is an approximately ₹ 10,000 difference for similar capacity), and seals require regular wiping down. Also, you cannot open these mid-way through a cycle.

Capacity varies from 5.5kg to 10kg, and price increases with capacity. Capacity of 5.5kg to 6.9kg is sufficient for a family of two to three, 7kg to 8kg capacity

for a family of four to five, and above 8kg to 10kg capacity for a family of six or more.

Warranty should be a minimum of two years on machine and at least ten years on the motor. Digital inverter technology helps conserve energy because washing machines with this feature consume power depending on load. Machines with inbuilt smart inverter technology have a longer lifespan, too. But this feature comes at an added cost.

Refrigerators

There are three deciding factors: capacity, frost-free technology and inverter compressor (increases lifespan of a refrigerator). Frost-free option does not require manual defrosting to remove accumulated ice.

Capacity is measured in litres—the higher the capacity, the higher the price. As we move from single-door and double-doors to multiple-doors and side-by-side doors, capacity also increases. Floral designs add beauty